

compromise or a stepping stone to a larger house, but a comfortable, desirable address for the long term.

Australians' love affair with detached housing is unlike the rest of the world. In the boroughs of New York, the districts of Hong Kong and the *arrondissements* of Paris, families live for decades in apartments. Swartz's experience is encouragement for first home buyers whose slender budgets require a rethink of the quarter-acre-block ideal. Swartz paid \$340,000 (no, that is not a misprint) in 2012 for the studio, and spent just over \$50,000 and six months transforming it into a bright and stylish home for him and his partner.

The original kitchen of the top-floor, north-east-facing pad was ripped out and relocated to create a 'pseudo one-bedder'. The floorplan was then separated into two zones by building a wall of bespoke joinery – on one side is the living room, dining room and kitchen, and on the other a bedroom and bathroom. The joinery has a dual purpose – in a property this titchy, everything needs to be a multitasker; a television unit is a book cabinet, opening up to a wine cellar, storage, desk, visitor seating and more. The clutter-free bedroom is a minimalist's sweetest dream – the end of the bed abuts the window as there is very little space, but the effect is calming and refreshing, and not just for the morning breeze which rolls in over Elizabeth Bay to fan the sheets. There is nothing spartan or cramped about this first home, which Swartz shifted into after years of shared housing. And cleaning it would be a cinch.

Although Swartz's architecture firm doesn't specialise in small-footprint living – a buzz phrase for ingeniously designed, affordable and compact homes – he has made himself a name for his big blue-sky thinking for wee, humble spaces. He didn't set out to live long-term in an apartment the size of a double garage in a typical suburban house, but that sentiment has changed. Swartz says of the day he signed the sale contract:

[The apartment] is in a really great location ... and it ticks a lot of the boxes – it was a perfect opportunity. I thought it would be something fun, and I would live in it for a year and hopefully